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UBI is the Bane of a Functioning Society

Let me say upfront that I know this is a controversial opinion.

Most kind, well-meaning people believe the opposite, and many people in technology and academia have been advocating for it loudly. But I have sat with the idea long enough to believe it is true, and I would rather be honestly unpopular than comfortably wrong.

One of the ideas floated over the last few years, usually by the rich, is Universal Basic Income (UBI).

Dario Amodei of Anthropic has recently suggested that since a large share of entry to mid-level white collar jobs is going to disappear due to AI, we should start thinking about some form of taxation to fund a UBI that supports the people left behind. Elon, ever willing to rebrand anything that aligns with his self-interest, has gone a step further and coined a better-sounding term, Universal High Income (UHI).

The core idea, shared by its supporters across academia, the wealthy, and even many who are themselves struggling, is to give everyone a minimum cushion, a monthly payment that covers basic living, so that people are freed to focus on bigger things that benefit everyone.

On the surface, it appears a kind and noble idea.

In a just society, everyone should be able to live decently and not have to struggle merely to exist. I want to live in a world like that.

And yet I believe the idea harms society, because it violates the most fundamental truth of how human behavior works.

Nothing of meaning, purpose, or value in our history has ever been built by people who had an

easy life.

Suffering is the core of human existence.

It is the single strongest force in the shaping of human character.

I believe suffering changes a person in one of two ways.

In some people, it turns into bitterness.

They ask why they were the ones chosen to suffer, while someone else was handed an easy life, untouched by the pain they were made to carry. The resentment slowly turns into anger, and they begin to hurt the world around them as revenge for their own suffering. They feel that if they had to suffer, everyone else should too.

But a few people go the opposite way. They come to believe that the purpose of suffering is to become so practiced at carrying pain that they can carry it for others, so that the people they love, and even strangers they will never meet, never have to feel the pain they once felt alone.

One takes their pain and hands it back to the world. The other takes the very same pain and makes sure no one else ever has to feel it.

Most people do not know what their passion is, and most will never know what their purpose is. More often than not, hardship is what forces a person to strive, to fight, and to change their situation.

Because nearly all of everyday life runs on money, the desire to make money becomes, for most people, the source of their ambition. For some, it goes further. Money is power, and the hunger to accumulate extreme amounts of it becomes the very thing that gets them out of bed each morning.

Take that away, and a quieter, more uncomfortable truth remains.

Without an innate drive, most people simply do not push themselves.

They will not push for money, for power, or even to escape their own suffering.

G. Michael Hopf described the cycle better than I ever could.

"Hard times create strong men. Strong men
create good times. Good times create weak men.
And weak men create hard times."

— G. Michael Hopf

Much of history is that sentence repeating itself.

Andrew Carnegie arrived in America as a penniless immigrant and went to work in a cotton mill as a boy, earning barely over a dollar a week. Hardship shaped him long before he built the steel that built modern America.

The pattern holds for entire nations. The generation that survived the destruction of post-war Germany and Japan rebuilt their countries into economic powers within a few decades. The hardship that should have broken them became the thing that drove them. Their children, raised in the comfort their parents earned, never had to summon the same intensity, and largely never did.

Suffering is most often the origin of greatness.

Take it away, and you take away the one thing that has made most people rise at all.

UBI works against its own stated intention on exactly that point. Its supporters say that if you free people from worrying about their basic needs, they will be liberated to build great things for society. But the opposite happens when you hand people free money.

The desire to be ambitious quietly dies. The suffering that once pushed people to strive is no longer there. The basic needs at the bottom of Maslow's hierarchy, food, shelter, and safety, are covered, and once they are covered, the drive to climb higher fades.

None of this is hypothetical, because we have run the experiment before, more than once.

In 1795, the English parish of Speenhamland introduced a system that, in spirit, was an early form of basic income. Wages were topped up from public funds to guarantee every family a minimum livelihood, indexed to the price of bread. The system was well-intentioned, and by most later accounts it was a catastrophe.

Employers slashed wages because they knew the parish would make up the difference, and workers lost the incentive to work harder than the bare minimum, since effort no longer changed their income. An entire class of laborers slowly grew poorer and more dependent, stripped of the dignity and drive that work had once given them. The remedy deepened the problem.

We saw a faster version of the same thing in our own lifetime.

During the pandemic, governments rightly rushed emergency stimulus and enhanced unemployment benefits to people. But for many lower-wage workers, the benefits paid more than their actual jobs did, so there was little reason to work ten hours a day when they could stay home and collect most of the same money. Businesses desperately wanted workers back, and many workers simply chose not to return. There was nothing lazy in that choice. It was human nature responding to the incentives placed in front of it, exactly as it always has.

You cannot pay a society to stay ambitious. The moment its needs are met for free, its ambition fades.

The most serious thinkers on freedom never argued that society should abandon its weakest.

Even Friedrich Hayek, the great defender of free markets and the author of *The Road to Serfdom*, accepted that a society as wealthy as ours can and should guarantee a minimum. He wrote that "*some minimum of food, shelter, and clothing, sufficient to preserve health and the capacity to work, can be assured to everybody*," and that this kind of security could be provided to all without endangering general freedom.

But notice the line he drew, because it defines the entire argument.

Hayek separated two very different kinds of security.

The first was security against destitution, a guaranteed minimum below which no one, especially those genuinely unable to provide for themselves, need fall. He embraced that kind.

The second was the security of a given standard of living, a guarantee of one's relative comfort and position compared to others. He warned against the second kind in the sharpest terms, because to deliver it the state must take ever more control over how people live, work, and are rewarded. **He argued that the second kind is the road to serfdom.**

UBI, in its universal and unconditional form, crosses that line.

It hands a full standard of living to everyone alike, to the struggling and to the idle, with no condition attached to any of it. And once sustenance is separated from any need to contribute, when even the capacity to work, the very thing Hayek wanted his minimum to protect, is no longer asked of anyone, you have not built a safety net. You have built dependence.

There is also a deeper danger.

When the majority of a society lives on payments handed down by the wealthy and the political class, the society loses more than its work ethic.

It loses the ability to endure hardship, to struggle, and to build.

People who can no longer build for themselves must depend on others to build for them, and that dependence is never free.

A society where most people rely on the state and the rich for their basic sustenance has quietly handed over its leverage. Power concentrates further in the hands of the few who fund the payments, while the many, comfortable but captive, slowly surrender their voice, their agency, and their right to say no.

People rarely oppose those who feed them, and a society that cannot oppose its benefactors can be led anywhere.

The cruel irony of UBI is that a policy sold as the great equalizer may become the great pacifier. In protecting people from every hardship, it also takes away their reason to rise.

I want a world where no one suffers needlessly, and I want that more than almost anything.

But the answer to suffering was never to mask it with free money. The answer is to give people the tools, the opportunity, and the dignity to fight their way out of it themselves.

In that fight, and only in that fight, human beings have always become who they were meant to be.